Renewals Specialist — Case Study

Scaled Customer Success · n8n

General Information

- ⏰ **Duration:** 60 min
- 🗓️ **Breakdown:**
  - **40 min — Task & Role-Play:** You are fully in charge of time-keeping for the different parts of this session.
  - **20 min — Debrief, Feedback & Reflection**
- 📩 **Before the session:** Spend about 2 hours on the task below and send your work to us 24 hours before we meet. You may use any tools you like, including AI and automation; tell us how you used them.

The Context

It is December 2026 and you have just joined n8n as the first Renewals Specialist in the Scaled Customer Success team. The team has four Scaled CSMs who currently handle renewals on top of adoption and churn risk, and they are overwhelmed: 221 renewals are due in Q4 and some are already overdue. A renewal counts as overdue the day after its renewal date. The VP of Customer Success expects on-time closure and an accurate forecast.

Your manager has handed you a first slice of the book: 10 renewals worth €375k ARR in total, one already overdue and nine due in the next 60 days. You also inherit one live negotiation that is stuck. You own the renewal transaction (quote, negotiation, order form, signature, CRM and billing). The CSM owns onboarding, adoption and the day-to-day relationship.

All customers, numbers and policies below are fictional and simplified for this exercise.

Your Materials

A. Your portfolio: 10 renewals, €375k ARR

Sorted by renewal date. Health comes from the CSM; usage is the change in workflow executions over the last 90 days. Manual means someone must send a quote and order form; auto means it renews unless we or the customer act.

Customer	ARR (€)	Renewal date	Type	Usage (90d)	Health	What we know
Vantage Freight	21k	15 Oct (overdue)	Manual	flat	Yellow	Quote sent 1 Sep. Two follow-ups, no reply. Billing contact is a shared inbox.
Northwind Logistics	48k	29 Oct	Manual	+12%	Green	No quote sent yet. Champion says "just send it". Last year they signed 3 days after expiry.
Pixelforge	26k	2 Nov	Auto	flat	Green	Card on file expired last month. Billing contact unknown.
Halden Health	45k	7 Nov	Manual	-35%	Red	Champion left in September. CSM has not met the new owner. Annual contract with 30-day notice to cancel.

Brightloop	36k	14 Dec	Manual	-10%	Yellow	Live negotiation, see section B.
Tessera Finance	50k	18 Nov	Manual	+5%	Yellow	Legal redlines on the MSA open since September. Procurement wants a vendor security review.
Lumen Retail	28k	21 Nov	Auto	+8%	Green	Asked for the invoice to be issued to a different legal entity.
Kestrel Analytics	35k	28 Nov	Manual	+40%	Green	Close to the execution cap on their plan. CSM thinks they will want more.
Marlowe Insurance	46k	9 Dec	Manual	flat	Yellow	Procurement needs a signed vendor questionnaire and DPA before they can raise a PO.
Quanta Labs	40k	19 Dec	Auto	-20%	Yellow	CSM heard budget cuts are coming in Q1. Customer has not responded to the last two check-ins.

B. The stuck negotiation: Brightloop

Brightloop is a 150-person B2B software company on our Enterprise plan at €36k a year, renewing on 14 December. Their champion is a senior automation engineer, Sam, who values the product. Procurement joined in October. We sent the quote 6 weeks ago, and this email arrived yesterday:

> *Hi, thanks for the quote. We are seeing a 10% drop in executions and our budget has been cut. Procurement needs: (1) a 25% discount on the renewal, (2) payment terms of net 60, (3) removal of the auto-renewal clause, and (4) a 3-month termination-for-convenience right. They also asked whether we can reduce the plan size to save money. If we cannot agree, we will evaluate alternatives. Sam*

The CSM adds in Slack: "Sam loves us, but the budget pressure is real. They have also had two support escalations this year that were slow to resolve."

C. Commercial policy (fictional, for this exercise)

Topic	Standard	Needs approval
Discount on renewal	Up to 5% for a multi-year (2-year) commitment, none for 1 year	6–12%: Finance. Above 12%: VP Customer Success
Payment terms	Net 30	Net 45: allowed. Net 60 or longer: Finance
Auto-renewal clause	Required in all order forms	Waiver: Legal and VP Customer Success
Termination for convenience	Not offered	Any such right: Legal, normally declined
Downgrade to a smaller plan	Allowed at renewal, priced at list for the new plan	None
Price uplift	5% on 1-year renewals	Waiving it counts as a discount
Quote lead time	Quote sent 60 days before expiry	n/a

🛠️ Your Task (40 Mins Total)

Part 1: Portfolio Triage & Forecast (12 mins)

- **The Challenge:** You have 10 renewals, one overdue and nine due within 60 days. Rank them by what you would do first and why.
- **Next steps:** For each renewal, give the next action, who owns it (you, the CSM, Finance or Legal) and a date. Call out anything you would escalate today.
- **Forecast:** Tell us how much of the €375k you expect to close on time, how much late, and how much you expect to lose, and which number you are least sure about.

Part 2: Negotiation Role-Play (18 mins)

Step into character: you are the Renewals Specialist and the interviewers are the customer.

- **Before the session:** Write your reply to Sam and a one-page plan with your target outcome, your walk-away position, what you would give and ask for in return, and who you need to involve internally. Assume the policy in section C is fixed unless you explain why and who must approve a change.
- **The call (15 mins):** The interviewer plays Sam and then Priya from procurement. Expect pushback and a few surprises. Show us how you handle them live.

Part 3: Scaling the Renewal Motion (10 mins)

- **The Automation:** Pick one repetitive step in the renewal process and show how you would automate it or use AI to do it faster. A rough workflow sketch is enough and a working prototype is optional.
- **Examples:** For instance, quote and order-form generation, overdue-renewal alerts, CRM hygiene checks, or answering security questionnaires.
- **Cover:** what triggers it, which systems it touches, what a human still checks, and how you would know it works.

Debrief & Feedback (20 mins)

- **Self-reflection:** 1–2 things that went well, and 1–2 things you would improve next time
- **Panel feedback:** each participant shares 1 strength and 1 development area
- **Q&A:** your questions about the role and the team

🏆 Evaluation Rubric

- Renewal Prioritisation & Forecasting
- Negotiation & Commercial Judgement
- Communication
- Process & Automation Mindset